Eventually, the exercise was called off for two or three days and we were asked to fall back to the start point. This time, the exercise went off smoothly with some successes and failures on both sides. Many lessons were learnt, and the good as well as the not-so-good actions were highlighted by the umpires and the Control HQ during the summing up. We were fortunate to have had no casualties during the entire exercise. A professional army must be prepared to accept some casualties during such exercises, as they ought to be conducted in conditions as close as possible to an actual war. However, I believe that losing lives due to callous and unjustifiable decisions in peacetime and even during war, is not justified.

Finally, on completion of this exercise, neither the commanding general nor the brigade commander could prove their points. The 'mobile defence' idea died a natural death within a year, once the principal players departed from the scene. No heads rolled and none was axed; the GOC and brigade commander both became lieutenant generals in due course, and of the two hard-pressed poor lieutenant colonels commanding the Redland and Blueland forces, one went on to command the Indian Army whereas the other retired as a colonel!

After a few months, I had to go on duty to Walong, my fourth visit to that remote corner of India. In those days, a round trip from the roadhead of Hayuliang to Walong and back was around 250 kilometres, and it was a gruelling trek of eight days. The portly but energetic brigade major, Deepak Summanwar, dissuaded me from going on foot and suggested that I accompany him in the Caribou aircraft doing a ration sortie to Walong. We took off from Tezu in that cargo plane at about 8 a.m. with fresh rations and provisions, including about twenty live goats and sheep (called 'meat on hoof' in army lingo) for the garrison.

Within an hour we were approaching the tricky and small air strip. As I recall, the aircraft followed the narrow valley, made a 'U' turn and then another small turn, and finally came in to land. Just before touching down the pilots realized they had overshot the runway, so the captain wisely decided to abort the landing and